

Field Overview: Disciplinary Structure and Growth Dynamics

Annual output in the Active Inference literature rose from 1 papers in 2005 to 139 papers in 2025—a transition from a niche within theoretical neuroscience to a multi-disciplinary research program spanning three primary domains and eight tracked categories. The corpus start of 2005 was chosen to capture Energy-Based Model and variational Bayesian antecedents [dayan1995helmholtz](#), [lecun2006tutorial](#) that preceded the formal introduction of the Free Energy Principle in 2006 [friston2006free](#) and its subsequent full elaboration [friston2010free](#). Our corpus, extracted from arXiv, Semantic Scholar, and OpenAlex and deduplicated to $N = 849$ papers (2005–2026), captures the breadth, tempo, and internal architecture of this expansion (Figure 1).

